

Group G

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Project Sponsor

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0.0 Business Need/Opportunity

Reach Autism Learning is a local non-profit organization that offers autism support services for families with young autistic children. They want to redesign their website to better reflect the organization's core mission and values, connect with their clients, and make a visually attractive and friendly site.

The opportunity given for the design team is a real-world application of software development working with a real business that will exist beyond the scope of this class. The team will explore, in conjunction with Reach, a modern and innovative web design that emphasizes the core of the organization's mission and values.

1.0 Project Reflection

1.1. Customer Base

1.1.1 Northstar Customer(s)

The website is targeted to the select group of people who are most likely to use the services and resources that Reach Autism provides. This is primarily the parents and guardians of young autistic children aged 4-17. The website should provide all the necessary information this customer requires and make them feel cared for and supported.

1.1.2 Carryover Customer(s)

The carryover customers for Reach Autism are the general populace and businesses that are interested in contributing to the cause, which is autism support. This demographic extends to people who are interested in volunteering, making donations, and learning more about autism. Other visitors to the site are potential sponsors and partner organizations. This type of user should be called to action, either to give their time and money to Reach. It should be clear that their help is necessary and greatly appreciated.

1.2 Project Assumptions

The design team made many assumptions before the project got underway. The first assumption was that the design process will follow the fast-feedback cycle, which consists of exploring, framing, brainstorming, and building stages. Between each cycle, the team will meet with the client (Reach Autism) who will provide feedback. The design team will have to modify or explore different ideas with the design to meet the client's needs. The design will constantly change.

Furthermore, the designers will be using the processes learned in ENSE 271 and outlined in the project guidelines. The process will consist of empathy mapping, affinity diagramming, User Story Maps (USM), and low- and high-fidelity prototypes.

The team assumed that the current logo for Reach Autism will not be changed, and all information on Reach's current website will be included in the final design.

Some assumptions made about the customers were:

- Families/users prefer simple, calming design but also user-friendly
- Donors and volunteers need clear calls-to-action
- Parents value visuals like gallery, events, children's experience and services offered

1.3 Constraints

The design team was constrained to specific pieces of software. Figma was used to create the high-fidelity prototype, and WordPress had to be used to create the final website. The default WordPress engine is limited in what it can do with respect to special functions. The team also had limited time to deliver all the necessary requirements, with only one or two weeks between check-ins with the clients. Another constraint for the project was the availability of each of the group members to attend meetings. To help mitigate this, a Discord server was created to schedule meetings and meet remotely, if necessary. This project had no budget to build a WordPress solution, and the website must be created using free plug-ins and add-ons.

1.4 Initial Key Findings

The findings from the introduction meeting of the client proved essential for laying the foundation of the project. After analyzing the client's feedback through empathy mapping and affinity diagramming, the following conclusions were drawn.

The website should cater to families. The community should be made aware of the services that Reach Autism Learning provides and should be able to easily access the resources they need quickly. There also needs to be a secondary focus on donors and volunteers. The site should engage the community and make it attractive for people to give their time and money. They need to understand the core of the organization's values and mission - they have to be made to care.

A problem with the current website is a discoverability issue. The new site must appear on a search for “autism support services Saskatchewan,” and capitalize on social media to extend their online presence.

The website should appear professional but friendly and authentic. It should be visual with not a lot of text, making it easy to read for people with accessibility issues. Designing for autism requires maintaining focus on the website, reducing clutter and removing anything distracting.

A major pain point for the clients was the current homepage to focus more on the mission and values.

1.5 Evolution of the USM and MVP:

The user story map was put together using four main areas in which a user would visit Reach Autism’s site, which are: who Reach is, what services they offer, and volunteering and donation options. This was determined using the key findings listed above. These formed the “epics” in the user story. The walking skeleton details which pages would belong under those four epics, and the story cards under them are a list of actions and information that would be found on those pages. In making the USM the team included everything that is on Reach Autism’s current website, making sure to include the findings from the initial conversation with the client. In terms of structure this is like what Reach currently has except with a more robust “Mission” section. The team also included some of the things discussed during the initial meeting that the client would like to have, or the team thought they should include, such as “testimonials,” “blog,” a recipes page (“health suggestions”), and applications for part-time work. The ideas for a blog and health suggestions were not in the initial USM but were added after those topics came up again during the first client check-in. Similarly, “testimonials” was moved from the first release to the Minimum Viable Product (MVP) after hearing feedback. There was an idea to book appointments for services but was ultimately slated for a later release as the site will include multiple ways to contact the organization. Lastly, all cards for “apply for part time work” were moved to a later release since it was not discussed with the client until the third check-in, where they mentioned there should be a place for it to be added later.

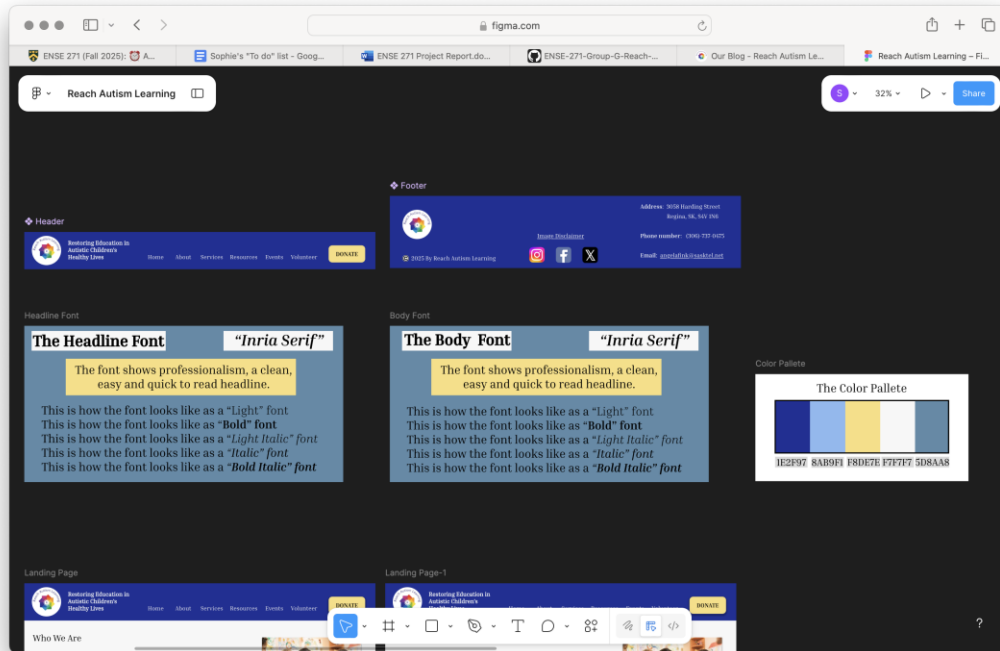
The final USM is an MVP because it includes all the necessary elements for users to have a complete experience while on the site. They can find out more about the organization, they can see what services Reach offers, contact them, donate and volunteer, and access some additional resources to throw in some delight. Everything else slated for later releases is not integral to this experience.

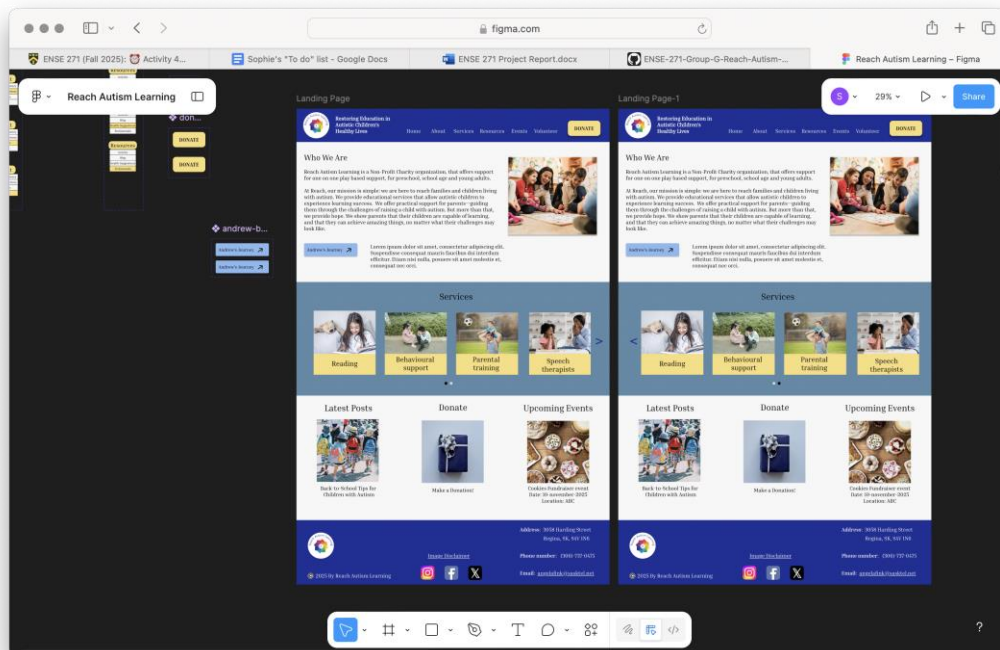
1.6 Summary of Prototype Activities

The team made several drawings of possible designs for the website which were shown to the clients. Using their feedback, a final low-fidelity prototype was drawn as a basis to design the high-fidelity prototype. The team used Figma to create this interactive prototype which was

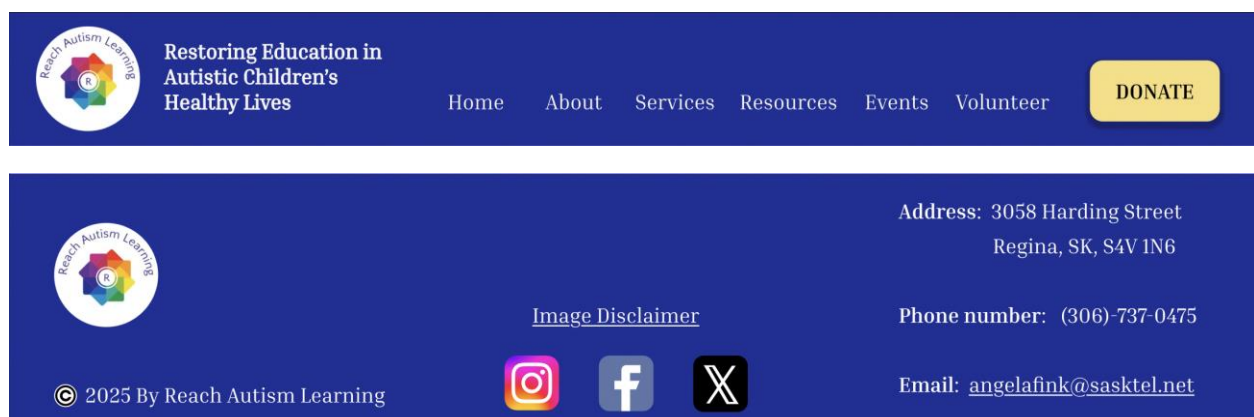
shown to the clients to receive feedback. The prototype was also tested with several users, and their feedback was evaluated. The prototype, along with the feedback that was gathered on it, was used as the basis for the final product.

With the prototype, similarity and consistency were used to create a cohesive design. Fonts, colours, and formats were kept the same throughout. Elements that belong to the same block are grouped together, and patterns of these blocks signify that they belong to specific sections.

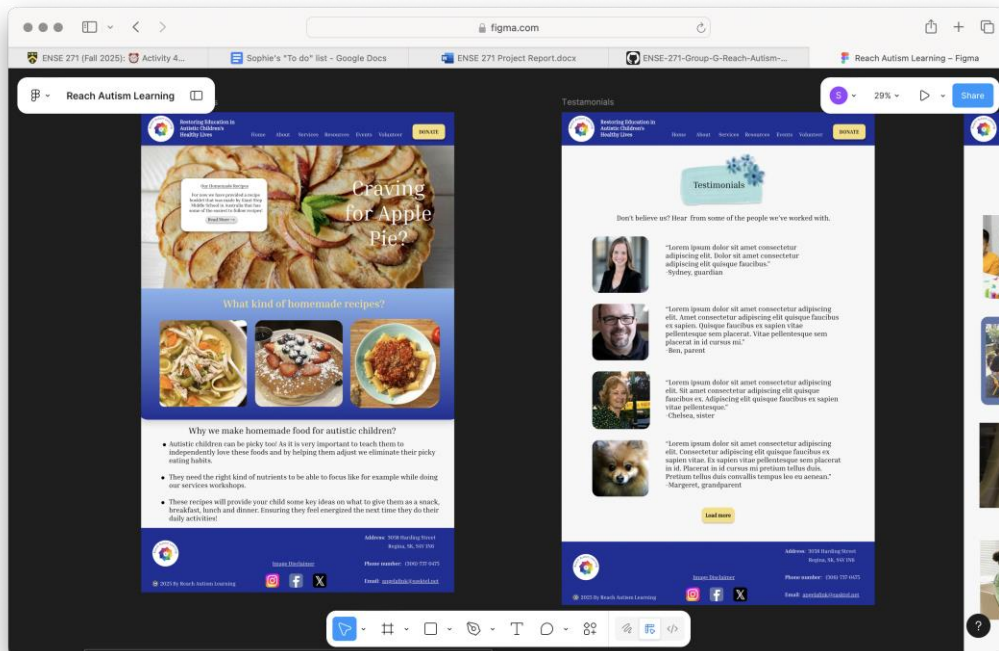
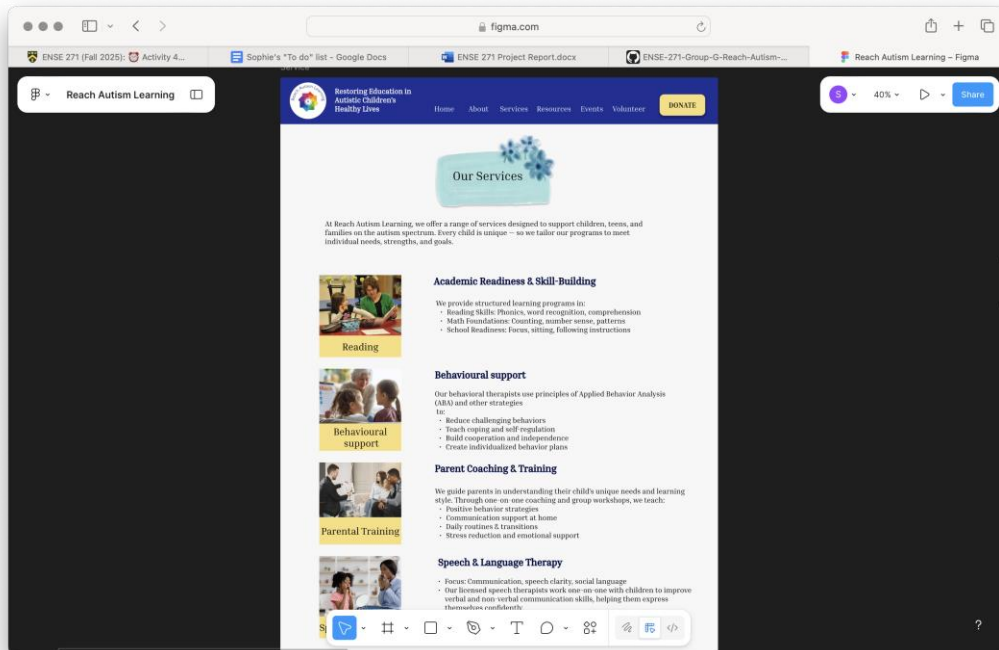




Buttons and interactions were signified by the element changing colour when the mouse hovered or clicked. There was a significant use of white space to break sections apart and make sections easily distinguishable. The footer and header could be identified by a coloured bar across the top and bottom of every single page.



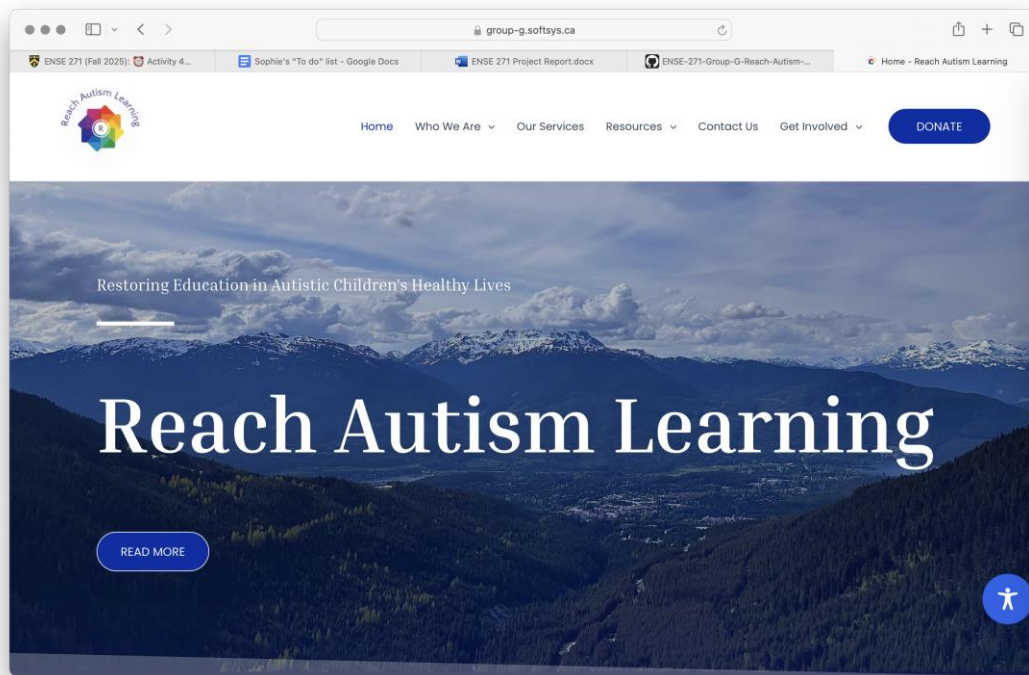
The initial, low-fidelity prototypes were received well by the client. When the high-fidelity prototype was developed, the main criticism of it was that it looked too professional and did not reflect the playfulness of the organization. This same comment was repeated during peer usability testing.

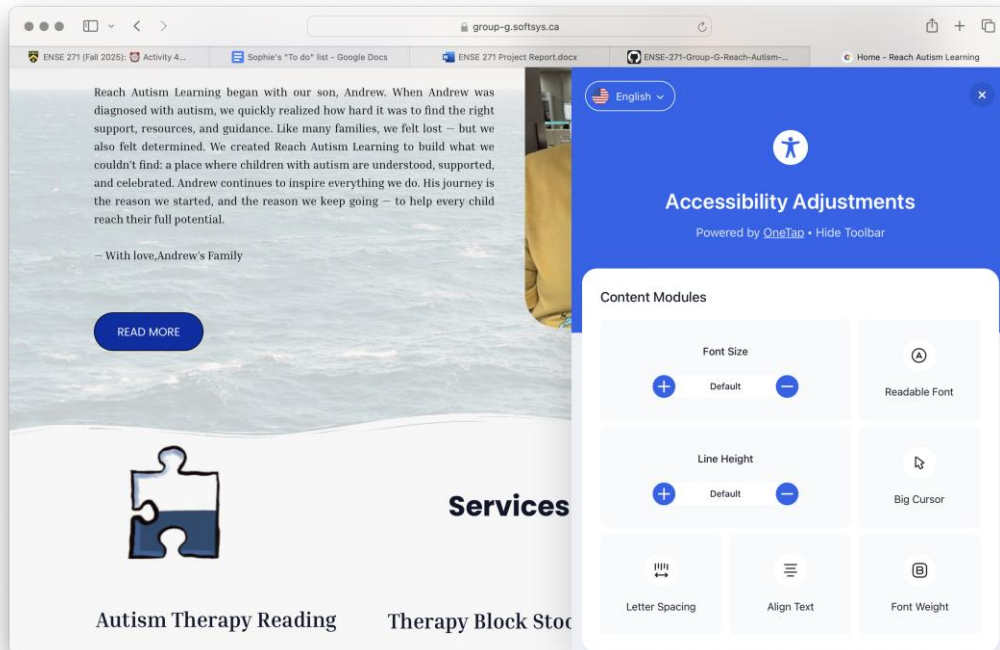


Another thing to consider was to remove the wordiness, especially on the homepage, and use images to create a more visual experience. There was also mixed feedback on a flower header used in initial drafts which led to it being removed.

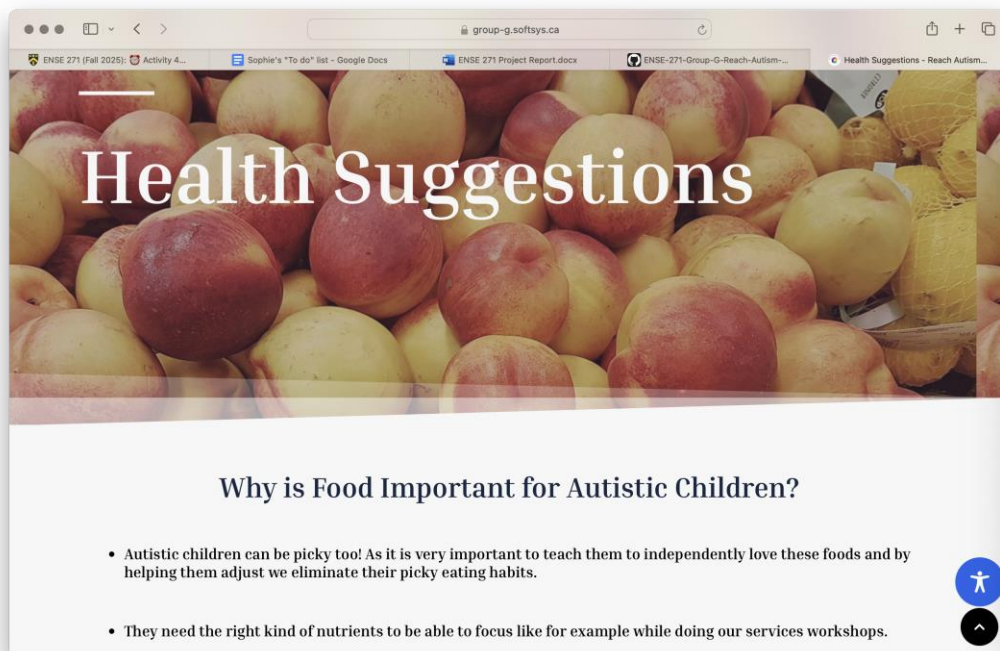
1.7 WordPress Solution Summary

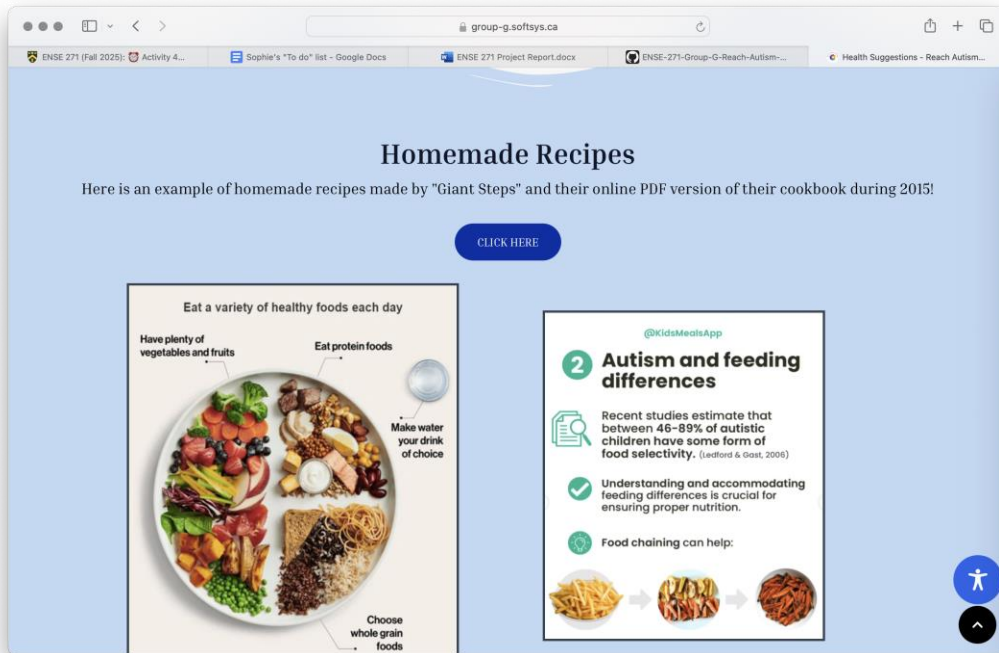
The final solution solved several problems such as accessibility, better ways to complete actions like donating or getting in contact through the website. One of the main ways accessibility concerns were addressed was with a plugin called OneTap which can be found in the lower right corner of the site. This is used to change elements such as font size, letter spacing, and more. It can also do more complicated actions such as changing contrast, highlighting links, incorporating a line for reading, etc.



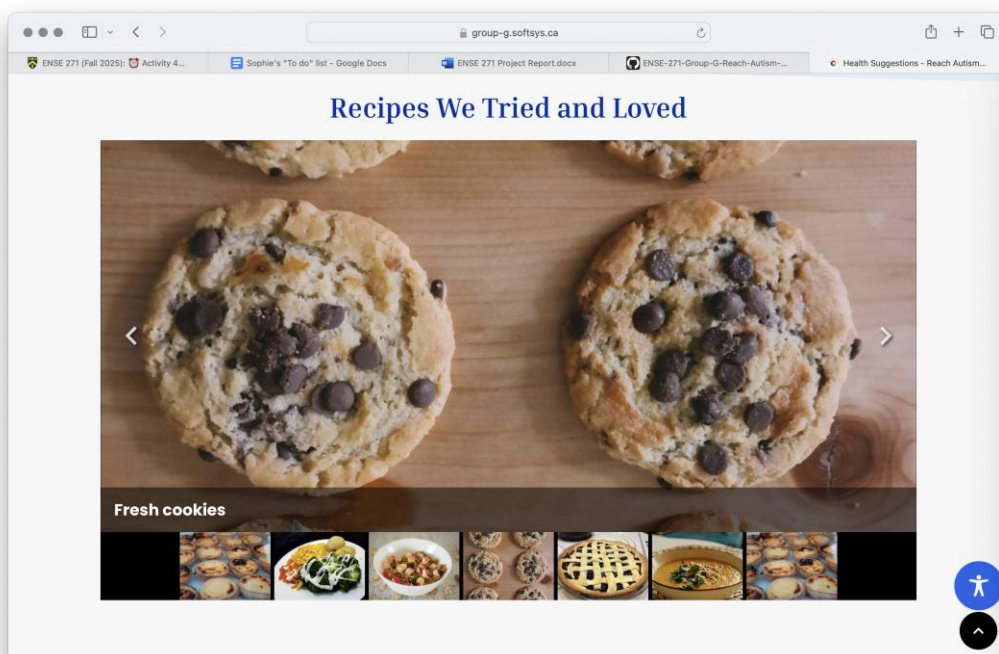


The team also added some features that enhance the results, like a Health Suggestions page that encourages parents and guardians to prioritize nutrition when caring for autistic children while also giving them some resources. This page provides an explanation of the importance of feeding children healthy food along with a pdf of recipes and a slide show where Reach Autism can showcase recipes they enjoyed.

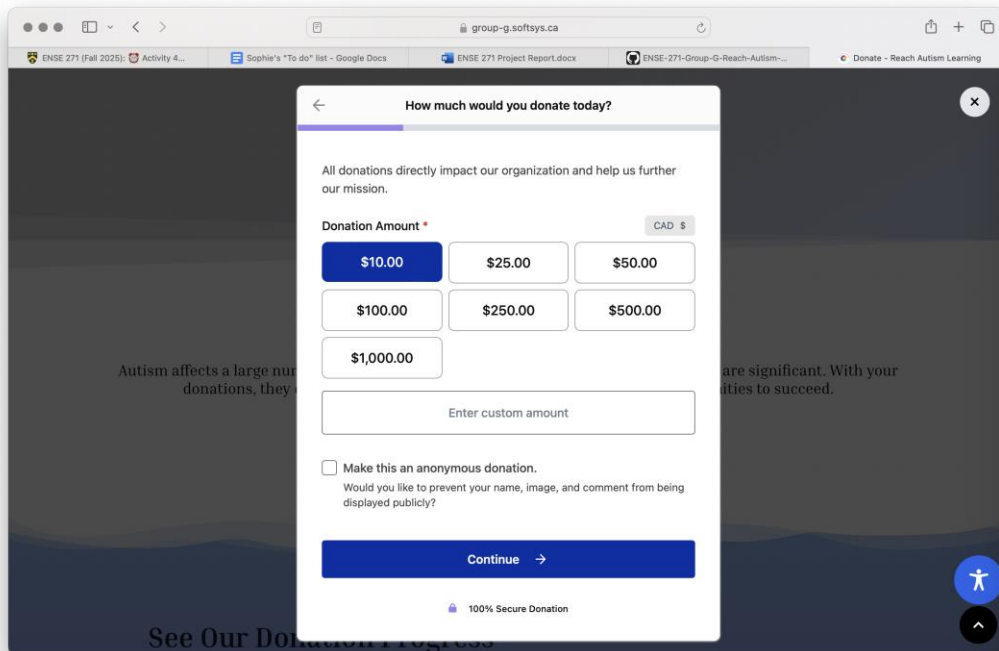




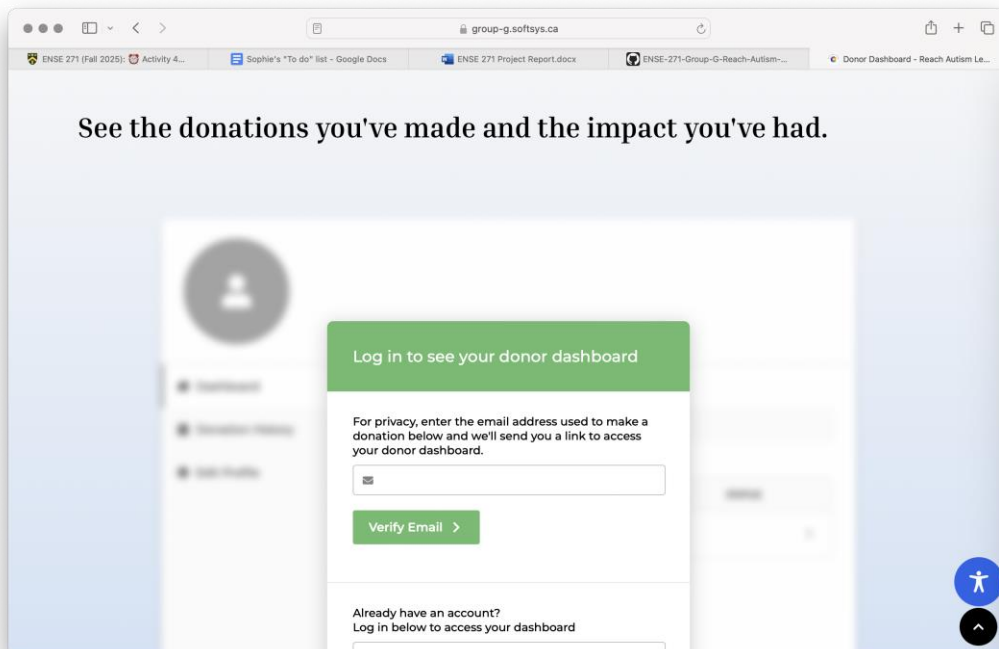
Also included were statistical photos of healthy foods in the “Health Suggestions” as this was something that might resonate to people with autism. A member of the group had an autistic uncle who loved numbers or statistical information and found it engaging.



Another key feature of the site is the donor process. The team has implemented a form on the donation page which allows for easy donations, along with a dashboard for users to see their history of previous donations. Additionally, an email is provided on the donate page to directly send money through e-transactions.

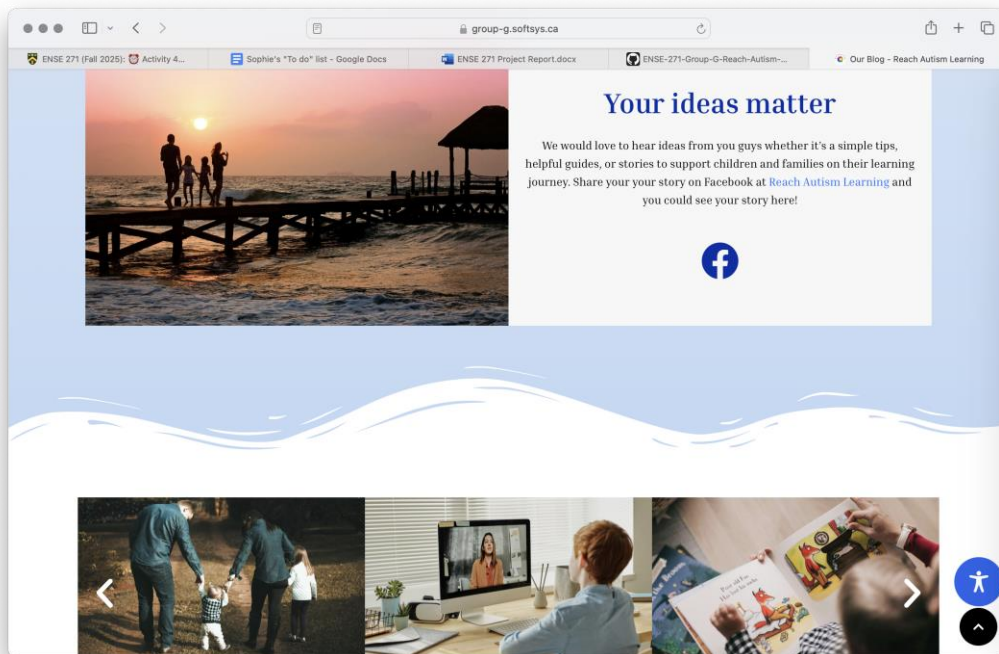


The screenshot shows a web browser window with the URL `group-g.softsys.ca`. The page displays a modal form titled "How much would you donate today?". The form includes a message: "All donations directly impact our organization and help us further our mission." Below this, there is a section for "Donation Amount" with a "CAD \$" label. It features several buttons for preset amounts: \$10.00, \$25.00, \$50.00, \$100.00, \$250.00, \$500.00, and \$1,000.00. There is also a text input field labeled "Enter custom amount". A checkbox option is present: "Make this an anonymous donation. Would you like to prevent your name, image, and comment from being displayed publicly?". At the bottom of the form is a blue "Continue" button with a right arrow. A small lock icon and the text "100% Secure Donation" are visible at the very bottom of the modal. The background of the page is dark blue with some text visible, including "Autism affects a large number of children and adults, and without proper support, they can experience significant challenges. With your support, we can help them succeed."



The screenshot shows the same web browser window with the URL `group-g.softsys.ca`. The page displays a login form titled "Log in to see your donor dashboard". The form includes a message: "For privacy, enter the email address used to make a donation below and we'll send you a link to access your donor dashboard." Below this is an email input field and a green "Verify Email" button with a right arrow. At the bottom of the form, there is a section for "Already have an account? Log in below to access your dashboard" with a corresponding input field. The background of the page is light blue with some text visible, including "See the donations you've made and the impact you've had."

Lastly, other things considered during the design process included making the site more playful and fun. To be more specific, adding shape, colour, and the right images all went into making the site look more child-friendly and interactive. Good examples of this are the Home page and the Blog page. Playing with the shape divider feature and putting it across the pages, this little detail helped the website bring out the inner child friendly and fun touch that the website needed.



2.0 Reflections on Project Results

2.1 Likes

The team liked the WordPress plug-ins used since it was easier for them as a group to work on each individual page. Without plug-ins it would have been difficult to design and would have looked boring and ordinary. Defining a color palette for the site was useful in designing the site, and the team really liked it. They went through around 2-3 iterations of the palette before they landed on one which looked really good on the website. The team thought that WordPress could be hard to learn, but they appreciate it more now as a group since they have accomplished a usable design with it. They also appreciated the reference to the customer's current website to give a basis for what to implement and improve the design from there. The team also liked each other and got along well, and were able to have open, honest conversations about the design without coming into conflict.

2.2 Dislikes

While the design team is proud of what they were able to accomplish, they did not like certain aspects of the web-building software WordPress. While liked, plug-ins were also a pain point during discussion since their full potential could not be used with the free version, and the team had a budget constraint. They could not freely design the website the way they would like, and it was difficult to find the right ones to use.

The client did not have a separate repository of images to pull from to use in the final design. The team had to individually download each photo and convert it to the proper file format (all photos on the current site were .avif extension, which WordPress does not support). It was a painstaking process that could have been better.

2.3 Summarize what went well during the project:

The team was happy that they were able to meet at least more than two times every week. They loved the openness of getting feedback and asking questions and expressing concerns freely. As a result, technical issues were easily overcome, and any concerns or problems could be swiftly addressed by talking through it as a group. As a group throughout the semester, there were no falling outs or any negative things that happened that could affect work progress. The team was well-coordinated throughout client meetings and presentations, and feedback assessment.

2.4 Summarize what did not go well during the project:

It was difficult learning the software to create the prototype and final solution. Both Figma and WordPress were new to most of the team, and those applications have a medium threshold. But as the skills and knowledge of the team improved, so did the ability for them to overcome that threshold. Additionally, when someone on the team was unsure of how to do something, everyone was onboard to help.

There was a struggle to fill in the information that was needed for each page since much of what was designed is new content not in the original site. There was much improvisation needed to adapt and provide appropriate information to finalize the website.

The team also struggled with finding the appropriate icons and keeping consistency across all pages. Those jobs fell to specific group members to distribute the work. With the design, it was difficult to implement customer feedback to make it a more personalized website experience than a professional business website. The team had chosen a theme and template that would have taken time that they did not have. The team played with different shapes and colours within the theme to try and achieve this.

2.5 How successful was your team in translating prototypes into WordPress reality?

There was success in translating the prototype; however, the site looks quite different due to the theme chosen and making changes to incorporate customer and user feedback. There was focus on ensuring the design was playful and consistent. Another important factor from the prototype to the result was making the site accessible and easy to consume. This meant making sure there was a visual format to make the content more digestible and breaking it up into more manageable chunks. As stated, previously feedback was integral to this success along with tools like the plug in OneTap (see Appendix).

2.6 Did the people-centered design ideas discussed in lectures help/hinder your design explorations?

The lecture topics were extremely helpful. A good example is discoverability and understanding which was brought up often when discussing how to make the design accessible and inclusive for users. This concept was also used when discussing how to make the site easier to find.

Another design principle used but didn't explicitly state or realize in the moment was data to information to knowledge. Meeting with the client and receiving feedback was the data collected. Information is what was taken away from those meetings, and knowledge was understanding what it meant in relation to what was learned so far.

Lastly, always keeping in mind the constraints and how they applied to the work helped the team think about possible roadblocks that might have been encountered and avoid them.

2.7 What would you do the same on future projects?

The customer check-ins as part of the fast-feedback cycle were extremely valuable as they were insight into what worked well in the design and what needed to be improved. For example, the content block on the homepage was considered too long, which led to the inclusion of a banner instead that added to the overall appeal. Additionally, customer check-ins also sometimes helped with what a problem was or how to solve it.

Using design tools like empathy maps and affinity diagrams, especially in the beginning, allowed for better understanding of the project requirements and what was needed to accomplish them. It also made the team think from the clients and/or users' perspective which proved to be incredibly valuable throughout the design process

2.8 What would you do differently on future projects?

The team is unsure of using WordPress in the future as it was difficult to work with in the beginning and still was by the end. It was frustrating due to the limitations in place, specifically without the full use of plug-ins and needing to pay for the premium version. Using web-

development software like React would give more freedom; the downside is that it requires skill in HTML, CSS, and JavaScript. However, WordPress does have more capability when compared to other website builders like Wix or Weebly, likely partially due to the number of plug-ins and themes.

2.9 Summarize opportunities and design ideas for future work

The project has given team skills in web design and the popular web design application WordPress. This can be translated into real job opportunities from small businesses and organizations looking to redesign/manage their websites.

For designing using WordPress in the future, the team would want to access better plug-ins or use premium versions to allow for more capability. This will likely be an option to consider as there will be a budget for the design team to work with.

Should the team be designing businesses local to the area, such as Regina or Saskatchewan, they would like to take photos and videos with the specific intent of adding them to the site, so there is no worry about copyright infringement. This would have the bonus of creating a connection with users because these are familiar and make them feel the business is close to them personally.

Going forward, it would be preferred if all relevant forms of media were provided in a flash drive or a folder by the clients beforehand, so there is less time spent looking for photos and videos.

Appendix: WordPress Themes and Plug-ins

Accessibility Widget by OneTap – Easy One-Click Accessibility Toolbar

Version 2.7.1

Average Rating: 5 stars

Active Installations: 20,000+

Description: OneTap is an accessibility plugin designed to make websites accessible and inclusive for all users by changing things such as font, text size, etc.

Astra by Brainstorm Force

Version 4.11.16

Average Rating: 5 stars

Active Installations: 1+ Million

Description: This website theme is described as fast, SEO friendly, compatible with a number of plugins such as Elementor, WooCommerce, Spectra, and more. It is also said to have a “mobile-first design” making it compatible with all devices.

Elementor

Version 3.33.2

Average Rating: 4.5 stars

Active Installations: 10+ Million

Description: Elementor is a professional website builder built to be developer friendly with widgets such as heading, text, and images along with key features like an intuitive drag and drop builder, a template library, and more.

GiveWP – Donation Plugin

Version 4.13.1

Average Rating: 4.5 stars

Active Installations: 100,000+

Description: GiveWP is WordPress’s most popular donation plugin. It has a free version and features like customized donation forms, manage donors, and donor data.

ReGallery

Version 1.17.10

Average Rating: 5 stars

Active Installations: 300+

Description: ReGallery is a photo gallery plugin for WordPress that uses AI to create responsive and SEO-friendly galleries.

Spectra

Version 2.19.16

Average Rating: 4.5 stars

Active Installations: 1+ Million

Description: Spectra is a website builder with block editing tools and templates for building better sites faster. Additionally, it focuses on speed and performance optimization along with being smooth and visually appealing.

Starter Templates

Version 4.4.43

Average Rating: 5 stars

Active Installations: 2+ Million

Description: A professional website builder with the assistance of AI. Some of its highlighted features include a large library of Elementor templates, hundreds of templates for WordPress block editing, fully customizable websites, a built-in AI assistant, and more.

SureForm

Version 2.1.0

Average Rating: 5 stars

Active Installations: 300,000+

Description: SureForm is a plugin for creating visually appealing forms with ease and zero coding. It specifically targets pain points such as design limitations, security issues, lack of mobile friendliness, and is compatible with different skill levels so beginners as well as those with experience can use it with little to no issues.

SureRank SEO

Version 1.5.0

Average Rating: 5 stars

Active Installations: 200,000+

Description: SureRank SEO is a search engine optimization plugin that is made to be simple and lightweight while also being powerful. It focuses on several things including a clutter free interface, visual content optimization, settings with minimal input needed, and more

Ultimate Addons for Elementor Lite

Version 2.7.0

Average Rating: 5 stars

Active Installations: 2+ Millions

Description: A plugin that extends Elementor capabilities with elements such as widgets, features, and blocks to make the design process more efficient. It helps design things like headers and footers that are visually engaging while also giving performance, control, and reliability.

WPForms Lite

Version 1.9.8.4

Average Rating: 5 stars

Active Installations: 6+ Million

Description: A WordPress plugin with a form builder that includes a drag and drop function and user experience as their number 1 interest. Additionally, it is made to be beginner friendly and features like pre-made forms, mobile readiness, and more.